Then for his sins, they filled his mouth with gunpowder, and blew him up. They threw his men in prison, and brutally tortured them until they became an example for any who claimed they were so fearless they were capable of resisting the exquisite pain of the torturer.'[25] Finally, according to Mohammad Khan Durrani, they strapped the offender's wife and children to Shuja's artillery and blew them from the mouths of the cannon.[26]

Amid all this civil and fratricidal war, Durrani Afghanistan quickly fractured into anarchy. It was during this period that the country accelerated its transformation from the sophisticated centre of learning and the arts, which led some of the Great Mughals to regard it as a far more elegantly cultured place than India, into the broken, war-torn backwater it was to become for so much of its modern history. Already Shah Shuja's kingdom was only a shadow of that once ruled by his father. The great colleges, like that of Gauhar Shad in Herat, had long shrunk in size and reputation for learning; the poets and artists, the calligraphers and miniaturists, the architects and tile makers for which Khurasan was famous under the Timurids, continued their migration south-eastwards to Lahore, Multan and the cities of Hindustan, and westwards to Persia. Afghans still regarded themselves as sophisticates, and Mirza 'Ata, the most articulate Afghan writer of the period, sounds like Babur when he talks proudly of Afghanistan as 'so much more refined than wretched Sindh where white bread and educated talk are unknown'. Elsewhere he talks of his country as 'a land where forty-four different types of grapes grow, and other fruits as well – apples, pomegranates, pears, rhubarb, mulberries, sweet watermelon and musk-melon, apricots, peaches, etc – and ice-water, that cannot be found in all the plains of India. The Indians know neither how to dress nor how to eat – God save me from the fire of their dal and their miserable chapattis!'[27]

Yet the reality was that the great days of high Timurid culture and elegant Persianate refinement were fast disappearing. Virtually no miniature painting survives from Afghanistan during this period, in striking contrast to the Punjab where Pahari artists were then producing some of the greatest masterpieces of all Indian art. A once great city like Herat was now sunk in squalor and filth. Ravaged by repeated outbreaks of cholera, Herat had shrunk within living memory from a population of 100,000 to less than 40,000.[28] The Durrani state, with its severe institutional weakness, was on the verge of collapse and Shuja's authority rarely extended further than a